

The Great Plains

The largest expanse of temperate grassland in North America, a fragile landscape shared between two nations and increasingly under threat



At around 3,000 miles (4,800km) long and 310–680 miles (500–1,100km) wide, the vast grassland known as the Great Plains covers the heart of the North American continent. It slopes gently downward from the Rocky Mountains east to the Mississippi River, and stretches from southern Canada as far south as Texas.

Types of prairies

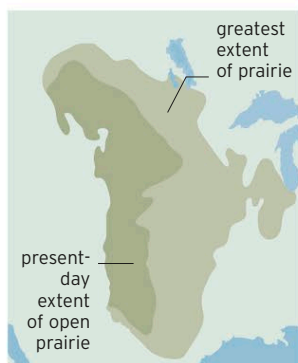
Once immense seas of grass known as prairies, much of the Great Plains today consists of seemingly endless fields of grain—primarily corn and wheat—planted on the most fertile soil. Other sections have been converted to cattle ranching. The natural grassland that remains consists of shortgrass and bunchgrass in the drier west, giving way to medium-grass and tallgrass prairie in central and eastern regions that receive more rainfall. Tallgrass prairie is among the world's rarest ecosystems. It is dominated by up to 60 different grass species, some of which reach heights of up to 8 ft (2.4 m), towering over an understory of flowers, lichens, and liverworts. These support a wide range of wildlife, from tiny western harvest mice and shrews to coyotes. All prairies are fragile habitats, and various programs are underway to preserve them.

Less than 1 percent of the original tallgrass prairies that existed prior to European settlement **remains**



NORTH AMERICA'S PRAIRIE TODAY

Land surveys estimate that up to 70 percent of the original grasslands that once constituted the Great Plains have disappeared, due to conversion of land for agriculture or for oil and gas exploration. Losses have been greatest in tallgrass prairies, while around 52 percent of shortgrass prairie remains intact.



△ SUPER STORM

Huge, violent supercell thunderstorms are common summer occurrences in the Great Plains. Their rotating updrafts often spin off tornadoes.

▷ RETURN OF THE HERDS

American bison were hunted almost to extinction by the late 19th century. Today, around 500,000 roam the Great Plains.

